

A coordination framework for councils, national government and the people on the frontline

Food System as Infrastructure

Food is back on the front page, and every level of government is being asked what it's going to do about it. This portfolio is the shared answer — a common set of foundations that council leaders, national government and the people running food projects on the ground can build on together, instead of 32 boroughs improvising 32 different pilots.

[Read the pathways](#)

[Open the working tools](#)

It grew out of borough food missions and food partnerships across London, and sits alongside Dark Matter Labs' Regen Nutrition and Nature as Infrastructure work. It is a portfolio of interventions and a shared toolset, not a single project.

Footage from the Future Food dinner and workshop at Calthorpe Community Garden and the Crowndale Centre, Camden.

Who this is for

City-wide Mobilisation

Food systems resilience is built across multiple different scales. A coordinated effort across food actors and London boroughs has been identified as the most

crucial element of a shared transition (be it in buying power of more resilient supply, distribution, local processing capacity or reserve). This call-to-all gathers actors to:

Council leaders

Use the most powerful local policy levers

Boroughs hold the most direct levers — public meals, procurement, land, local partnerships. This initiative aims to map the tools already within boroughs' mandate and show how they connect to food resilience and preparedness.



London, regional level

Pool buying power across London boroughs

Working across boroughs, in public health, regional development or infrastructure — this is about coordinating what boroughs are doing on the ground, and pooling the buying power no single borough has alone. The Greater London Authority and the NHS sit here too.



Scale and accelerate work already happening on the ground

Growers, grocers, [community kitchens](#), [food partnerships](#) — this maps the policy environment that could support your work and the economic circuits you could become part of. The governance and financing case is being built around what you're already doing, not instead of it.



National government

Build local proofs to encode new food economics

The enabling infrastructure — the frameworks and fiscal instruments that make local and regional action scalable — sits at this level. We aim to strengthen existing and build new coalitions to influence national policy.



Whether you lead a council, think about a cross-borough coalition, work in national government, you're already doing this work on the ground, or want to help develop financing and economic infrastructure around it — tell us where you fit, and how you'd want to be part of the next phase.

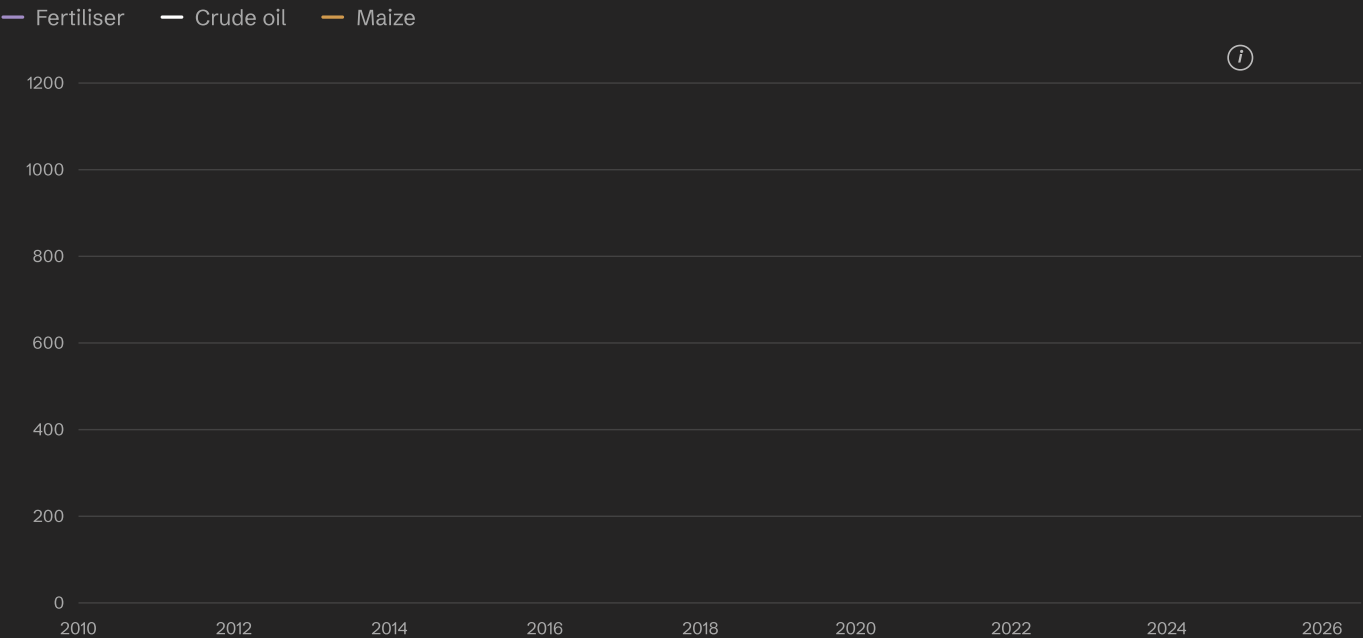
[Tell us where you fit ↗](#)

Why now

The food crisis is finally getting attention. ⓘ

Food inflation is forecast to reach around 9% by the end of 2026 ⓘ, and the Food Foundation’s basic-basket tracker already shows prices roughly 30% higher than in April 2022 — a second price shock inside four years, arriving on top of the first.

Food commodity and input prices, 2010-2026



9-10%

Whole-basket food inflation, forecast

Dec 2026

+90%

Iceberg lettuce, wholesale — with tomatoes +60% and potatoes +40%

Sept-Oct 2026

Sources +

The Joint Intelligence Committee and Defra have both gone further, warning of a strategic risk of catastrophic UK food system failure **by 2030** — not a distant scenario, but inside the term of whoever is in office right now.

This isn't the first attempt. The UK has passed roughly **689 food and health policies and 14 national strategies over the past 30 years**, with no measurable dent in obesity or health inequality to show for it.

That's exactly the moment London's 32 boroughs risk running 32 more uncoordinated pilots — each rediscovering the same procurement problem alone, the way national policy already has, repeatedly. The pathways below exist so that doesn't happen again.

Coordinated response for long-term resilience is the part that's missing.

The case, in their words

“

We need to be preparing a system that will have a lot less surplus and waste in it.

Carl Saxton-Pizzie — CEO, Wholegood

“

Rather than “chasing cut-price deals around the world,” public buying power should back domestic, resilient supply.

Andy Burnham — Mayor of Greater Manchester

“

In Bury, embedding health and climate value into catering contracts pushed school-meal menus to **up to 25% organic** ingredients — proof collective procurement can move real farmland, not just budgets.

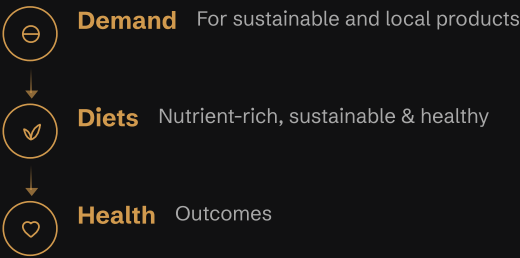
Soil Association, on Bury’s local food system transformation

Pathways

Four pathways that build food system resilience and preparedness

through connecting the demand and supply

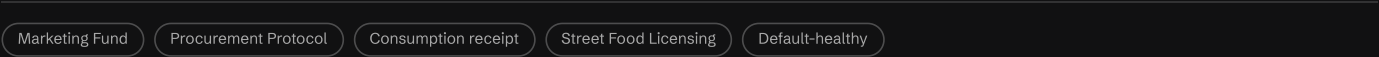
There are multiple plausible ways to transform the food systems. The pathways below set direction, organise interventions, and actors around resilience, health, environmental, economic vitality, and equity & fairness outcomes — each one makes the next possible, and skipping one is usually why a pilot doesn’t survive contact with scale.



Pathway 1

Civic-led delivery, civic resilience and preparedness

Procurement protocols and buying coalitions don’t feed anyone on their own. Grocers, dinners, workshops and community-run hubs are the layer that turn food into fresh meals someone can buy or receive.



Pathway 2

Coordinated, collective buying power of organic, resilient supply ⓘ

No single borough's contract is big enough to move a farmer's decision. A buying coalition of London boroughs and businesses is — turning committed public and commercial demand into the confidence a grower needs to convert land.

- Farmacy
- Public-interest grocers
- Multi-ledger ownership
- Collective buying engine

Pathway 3

New Food Economics

New economics of food through policy, economic, accounting, financing, and monetary instruments. Sounds complex — plenty of best practice to learn from.

- Food-value ledger
- True-cost accounting
- Prevention capital
- UBNI entitlement

Pathway 4

Nutrient density is the target, not calories ⓘ

The baseline shifts from “enough food” to genuinely nourishing food — because a system that only solves for calories quietly manufactures the next public-health crisis while claiming to have solved the last one.

- Organic conversion
- Farm-to-farm coverage
- Nutrient density
- Climate-controlled
- Labour & assets
- Baseline food stack



Supply De-risking farm transitions



Soils Nutrient-rich, sustainable & healthy



Environmental Outcomes

In plain terms +

The portfolio

What rides on each pathway

Every item below sits on one of the four waves above — hover a row to find its point on the wave. **Demand** makes healthy food easier to choose. **Hub** is the shops, pharmacies and services people actually walk into. **New Food Economics** is the instruments that make the other three payable. **Supply** makes sure enough good food is being grown in the first place.

Show the full table

Why adjustment isn't enough

What if the market-based food system we've relied on has already failed

— and a fairer model, one that works for growers and nourishes communities, is what comes next?

The economics of food don't move by tinkering at the edges — they move with a genuinely new arrangement of ownership, contribution, and price.

Look at the current food market as a product that's failing and you get edge-adjustments: a nicer label, a voluntary pledge, food surplus recycling with CO2 certificates, that do a lot of good but do not change the underlying logic.

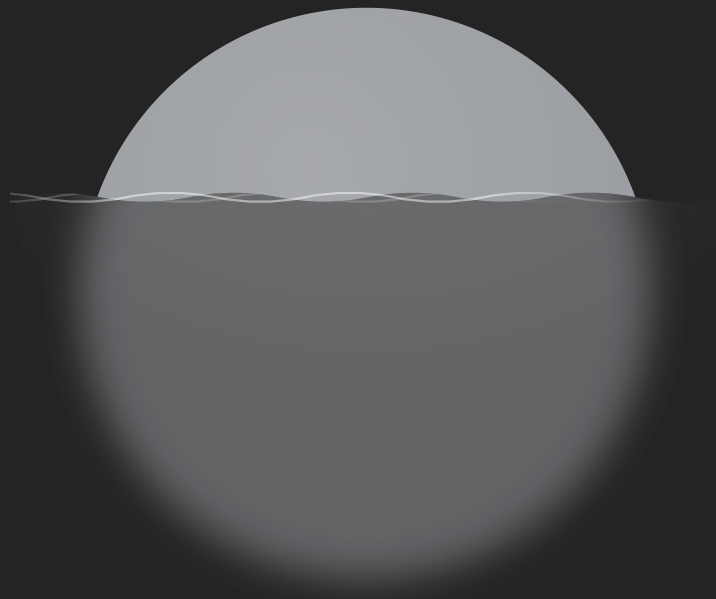
Look at the market-based nutrition as a product that has already failed — generating externalities and vulnerability faster than it delivers continuity — and the theory of intervention changes completely.

Public-interest grocers already show the gap: prices structurally lower on a fixed cadence, not “voluntary contributions” bolted onto a still-too-expensive shelf.

In plain terms +

Adjusting the edges +

- Shelf price
- Labels and pledges
- Surplus redistribution



- Assumptions about the future
- The value of good nutrition
- The externalities of poor diets
- The economics of the food system
- Monetary transition

Rebuilding the arrangement +

Adjustment only ever reaches the sharp edge above the line.
Ownership, contribution and the externalities sit below it — never
priced, so never in focus.

Who holds the line

Governance that can't be voted back onto the market

We need rules that stop this work being sold off or quietly undone later — similar to how some housing co-ops are set up so no single vote can ever put the building back on the speculative market (*Mietshäuser Syndikat*). The question is then:

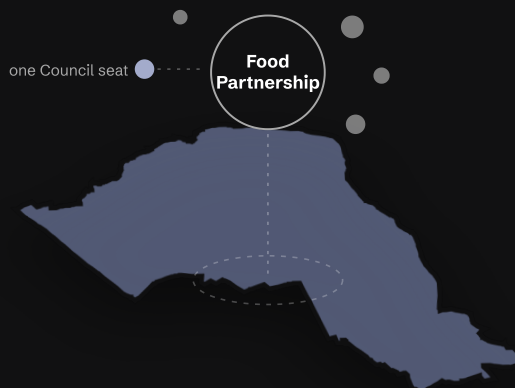
**Can food infrastructure be governed in a way that stays “with the people”
and scales at the same time?**

Tier 1, borough

An independent Food Partnership

The Council keeps a seat at the table — funding, convening,
advertising the work — without holding the steering wheel.

A declared, public work programme replaces “come and collaborate.”



Tier 2, London

A coalition of boroughs

Peer boroughs — starting with a founding group of neighbours — take on shared standards, collective buying, and a common protocol, so the model compounds rather than repeats from zero each time.

The Future Food Dinner — an experiential, cross-sector convening format already tested in Camden — is the concrete mechanism for building that coalition one peer group at a time, not just its stated ambition.

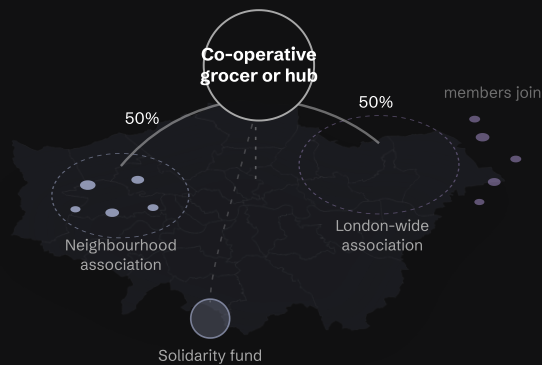


Governance

Distributed Governance

Distributed governance consisting of multiple self-supporting nodes, where ownership, stewardship, and voting rights are

distributed so the structure prevents speculation and keeps it in the hands of the community.



Tier 3, policy

Local evidence building National Policy

A policy briefing routed through leading experts and universities to national government, timed to a six-month window, arguing for the deregulation that lets already-brilliant local actors build without red tape.



Accountability layer +

A charter sits across all three tiers: what it takes to count as a genuine partner, and visibility between members so nobody drifts.

Precedent & our role +

The “as infrastructure” move has done this work before — for urban canopy, through TreesAI.

Set up a Local Food Resilience Committee — before the law requires it

In plain terms

Every council should set up a small group — public health, local food businesses, food banks, community groups — whose job is spotting food problems early and knowing what to do if supply is disrupted. Government is deciding by 5 October 2026 whether to make this a legal requirement.

The National Preparedness Commission's 2025 review, led by Tim Lang, recommends every local authority establish one as a matter of urgency. The Cabinet Office is now reviewing the Civil Contingencies Act 2004 to decide whether to make it statutory — with a call for views closing **5 October 2026**. A borough that moves first has already done most of that work before the law asks for it.

What it actually does

-  Maps local food supply chains — most places genuinely don't know where their food comes from or where the vulnerabilities sit
-  Feeds local risk data into Community Risk Registers and the borough's existing Resilience Forum
-  Acts as an early-warning system for civil society on food matters, tailoring national advice to the local context
-  Builds the cross-sector trust and expertise network a real emergency response actually needs

Who sits on it

-  Public health & environmental health specialists, trading standards
-  Food businesses across the system — present, not dominant
-  Civil society: food banks, Citizens Advice, faith and community groups
-  Co-chaired by someone with local standing — typically the Director of Public Health or an Emergency Planning lead

What coops are for

Cost-of-living, food access, and community ownership. Valuable — but not built for emergency planning, risk assessment, or public communication during a shock.

What the committee is for

Emergency prevention and response — working alongside the coops, the Food Partnership and the Borough Resilience Forum, not replacing any of them.

[Read Tim Lang's report ↗](#)[Respond before 5 Oct 2026 ↗](#)

Three horizons, not one deadline

The portfolio is built to be true at three different speeds at once — because the people in the room for this work are living in different horizons already.

- Now — before 5 Oct 2026

Shock absorption

Food-price volatility and nutrition inequality are already moving cognition and health outcomes. The immediate, concrete move is standing up a Local Food Resilience Committee and responding to the Cabinet's call for views before it closes — not waiting for a council procurement cycle to catch up.

- Next — 12-18 months

Coalition & charter

The Food Partnership publishes a declared work programme, four London boroughs sit down together on collective buying, and a policy briefing lands with national government inside its six-month window.

- 2028 and beyond

The labour shock

Automation reaches logistics and white-collar work at scale. Food-as-infrastructure is the argument for treating nutrition as social-contract security before that shock arrives — not the response to it afterwards.

The tools and work developing behind the argument

Each of these is a real, evolving model rather than a static deck — built to be interrogated, forked, and carried into the next room.

The Negative Portfolio

NP 2.0

An indicative portfolio of work that treats food fragility not as a supply deficit, but as a demand-construction opportunity. The Negative Portfolio v2.0.

[Open the navigator ↗](#)

An Implementation Pathway

Pathway

A breakdown of the pathway to actually implement the portfolio — from idea to intervention, in sequence.

[Open the pathway ↗](#)

Nutrition Cascade Model

Cascade

A working model of how a single food-system shock fans out across many pathways at once — not one line, but a system moving together.

[Run the model](#)

Nutrition Supply Map

Supply

Where the food actually comes from — and the shocks that travel home with it along the same routes.

[Trace the supply lines](#)

The Live Map — with audio briefing

Live map

A dynamic map bringing together the existing food system across London — hubs, retailers, growers, and routes in one place, with a built-in audio update for anyone who'd rather listen than read.

[Open the live map ↗](#)

A Sovereign Food System

Money & policy

A portfolio of economic and monetary instruments for food-system transformation — from municipal procurement and local currencies to a national investment bank. Built for, and developing on the ground in, Sweden — with lessons that carry directly to other contexts, the UK included.

[Explore the portfolio](#)

Hubs and Markets Working Group

Hubs & markets

Where existing food hubs, markets and civic spaces get mapped, matched and coordinated with each other — the working group carrying that forward.

[Open the working group](#)

Pathways

Six Pathways to a Civic Food System

Six distinct levers for moving London's collective buying power behind organic and regenerative farms, nutrient-dense food, shock resilience, and civic-led ownership — set out side by side, with an honest read on where the portfolio already has traction and where the gaps are.

[Explore the pathways](#)

New to this?

Start here

This page makes a lot of claims. These are the primary sources behind them — useful whether you're a council officer checking the evidence or a community group looking for who else is already working on this.

Government & risk assessment

[Joint Intelligence Committee](#) — national risk assessments, including food system resilience

[Defra](#) — UK Food Security Report & food system oversight

[The National Food Strategy](#) — the independent review this portfolio sits alongside

[Food Data Transparency Partnership](#) — Defra's work on nutrition & climate labelling

Research & evidence

[Nourishing Britain](#) — Dr Dolly van Tulleken, on why UK food policy struggles to stick

[Just in Case](#) — Tim Lang's National Preparedness Commission review

[Priority Places for Food Insecurity Index](#) — where the risk actually concentrates

[Farming Systems Trial](#) — Rodale Institute's 40-year organic vs. conventional comparison, on drought yields and soil water

[Nutrition Continuity](#) — the concept paper behind the Cascade Model & Supply Map above

On the ground

[City Harvest](#) — surplus food redistribution at scale in London

[Independent Food Aid Network](#) — the UK’s independent food bank network

[Magic Breakfast](#) — school breakfast provision & advocacy

[Veg Power & Bite Back](#) — youth-led campaigns on food marketing

We are building options for the next economies.

Food as Infrastructure is a Dark Matter Labs research, coordination and funding-orchestration programme — working with Camden and other London boroughs genuinely moving the needle on this work. It is stewarded to be lifted, borough by borough, into a London-wide portfolio — not owned by any one of them.

Portfolio	Tools	Dark Matter Labs
Who it's for	Negative Portfolio	Initiatives
The pathways	Implementation pathway	Projects
Supply / Hub / Demand	Cascade model	Contact
Governance	Supply map	
Resilience committee	Live food system map	
Horizons	Sovereign food system	
	Hubs and Markets Working Group	

Lineage & credit

This portfolio draws on the Camden Food Partnership's ongoing work, the Multi-Agency Healthy Weight Driving Group, the London Hubs & Markets Working Group, and prior Dark Matter Labs work including [Trees as Infrastructure](#). Parts of this site were drafted with the assistance of AI tools (Claude); the underlying research, judgement and direction remain those of the Dark Matter Labs team and named partners.

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